We must also prioritize time and resources for improvements of the statistics. Every policymaker should kick off long-range initiatives to improve statistics in her area. Economic statistics is not just the work of the CSO—it is the work of myriad persons all across the economy. We must prioritize the capture of information and the release of information.

When sound new statistical measures come about, at first they will have inadequate and short time series for a long time. Often, we will not be the beneficiaries of the statistical system improvements that we initiate. Just as *a country becomes great when men plant trees that they will not live to enjoy the shade of*, a country becomes great when men and women initiate data-gathering efforts that they will not live to enjoy the fruits of.

Example 56: Outcomes measurement in education

The most famous episode in India of outcomes measurement was the work by Pratham, to measure what schoolchildren know, through their Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) survey. ASER measurement has two great strengths. First, ASER measures outcomes (what children know) as opposed to the traditional measurement of inputs (school buildings built, teachers hired, etc.) or outputs (kids enrolled). Further, ASER is not part of the government, and it is hence more immune to pressures to distort the data or block the release of data when the data is painting an unflattering picture.

ASER surveys began in 2005, and have been extremely influential in showing the lack of learning achievements by schoolchildren in India. When you compare this data against the launch of Sarva Shiksha Abhiyaan (2000–01) and further back to the launch of the District Primary Education Programme (1993), there is a sense that we would have fared much better if an ASER-style measurement had begun much earlier. This would have created feedback loops and helped rapidly improve the design decisions